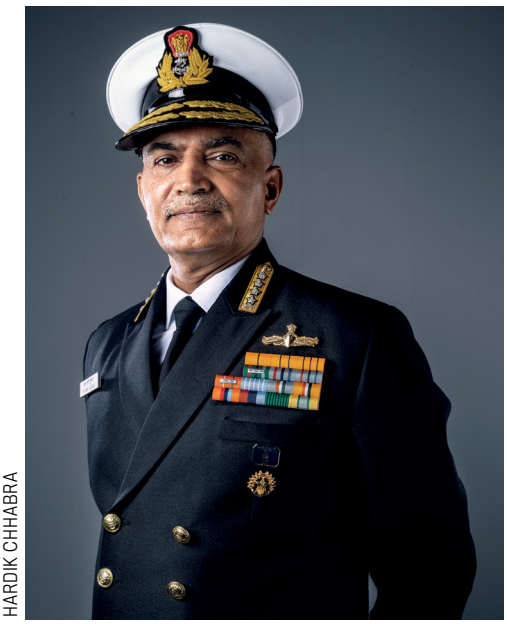
INTERVIEW

'WE'RE MONITORING THE BUILD-UP OF THE CHINESE NAVY'

Chief of Naval Staff **ADMIRAL R. HARI KUMAR** *is enthused by the induction of India's first indigenous aircraft carrier INS* Vikrant*—a floating airbase of fighter jets. In an exclusive interview to* **PRADIP R. SAGAR,** *Admiral Kumar spoke about the status of a third carrier, how the Agnipath scheme will bring about a balance of youth and experience, and why the proposed Maritime Theatre Command will help synergy*



HARDIK CHHABRA

Q. The Chinese navy is on an expansion mission and is projected to operate up to 10 carriers by 2049. How do you see this?

A. The Chinese navy's force accretion has been rapid. We are monitoring their build-up. The Indian Navy has plans in place, based on a constant scan of geo-security developments, to ensure our interests are always protected. In this, aircraft carriers have a crucial role to play—for India to have the capability to dominate the Indian Ocean and project power away from its shores. They are central to fleet operations and the concept of Sea Control, as they offer flexibility of a very high order...across vast maritime spaces. We feel a third carrier will further our objectives.

Q. What's the status of the Navy's demand for a third carrier?

A. Considering the indigenous expertise available, a repeat order (of) the IAC-1 (Indigenous Aircraft Carrier-1), with suitable modifications, is being explored. Additionally, broad contours have been formulated for an electric-propelled, 65,000-tonne carrier employing Catapult Assisted Take-off but Arrested Recovery (CATOBAR). The projects are yet to be accorded Acceptance of Necessity.

Q. When can we expect INS *Vikrant* to be deployed? Has its fighter jet fleet been finalised?

A. Getting aircraft carriers ready for operational deployment is a complex task. It involves multiple agencies and has many variables. Every aspect has to be seamlessly integrated. This is true the world over. Our endeavour is to complete flight trials and SRGD (Short Refit Guaranteed Dry Docking) of *Vikrant* by 2024. The Navy is looking forward to flying the indigenous Twin Engine Deck-Based Fighter (TEDBF) from our carriers. Till the time the project reaches fruition, we are looking at options to ensure the operational exploitation of our carriers and their deck-borne fixed wing fighter aircraft. The carrier will operate MiG 29K currently and MRCBF (Multi-role Carrier Borne Fighters) and TEDBF in future.

> **THE NAVY SUPPORTS THEATERISATION AS ADDRESSING VITAL MARITIME CHALLENGES NEEDS HIGH LEVELS OF STRATEGIC AND FORCE SYNERGY**

Q. How will you balance the high turnaround of sailors who would join under the Agnipath scheme, as the Navy is a tech-intensive force?

A. The Agnipath scheme will lead to a more youthful, technically adept war-fighting force. The permanent cadre—personnel enrolled after four years—would be provided niche operational and technical skills. The youthful Agniveers will comprise the dynamic rank and file. Whilst the seniors provide 'Hosh and Anubhav', the Agniveers will provide the 'Josh and Jazba'. Modified training methodologies will ensure that the high turnaround has no impact on professionalism, fighting spirit and camaraderie.

Q. Efforts to create theatre commands in the Indian military have not moved ahead. What is the Navy's stand?

A. The Navy has been a strong proponent of theatre commands. It is working towards positive outcomes from the ongoing deliberations. India is a maritime nation, and that domain necessitates an integrated approach and high levels of synergy in strategy, planning and application of force. The proposed Maritime Theatre Command would amalgamate core competencies of the three services and the coast guard. ■

(Read full interview on www.indiatoday.in)